



**MASTERMIND
INDIA**

Spirit of India Special

By Nishika Patel

The blockbuster *3 Idiots* saw an IIT student develop an unmanned aerial device that could snoop into his friend's dormitory room. It was more than familiar to Ankit Mehta, 27, who created the device during his student days at IIT-Bombay and loaned it to director Rajkumar Hirani. His story didn't end there. Along with two IIT-B friends, 26-year-olds Ashish Bhat and Rahul Singh, Mehta went on to set up

AN EYE IN TH

Mumbai-based company Idea Forge in 2008 and has turned the college project into a high-tech, spying device called Netra. The budding entrepreneurs have received orders from the defence sector and are currently figuring out how to scale up production.

It took the team two years to create an application called Bluefire Ground Control, which uses Google maps to chart a route for the plane, which can travel at a speed of 35 kmph and up to 300 metres high. Once the route has been tapped into the system, the 1-

metre wide plane will fly at the click of a button on its own for half an hour up to a distance of 1.5 km. A camera is placed in the middle of the machine, which provides a live video feed. Mehta says the device has multiple uses. It could be used by the army for reconnaissance work, by the navy to track pirate ships, as an internal security device in terror situations like 26/11 and in the surveillance of national monuments. "When a battalion is on the move, it is navigating in unstructured areas. Soldiers want to know what

Ankit MEHTA, 27

INNOVATION

Netra, an unmanned aerial vehicle

SELLING COST

Rs 10 lakh-1 crore according to the configuration

WHAT IT DOES

It can fly for half an hour up to a distance of 1.5 km, with a camera that provides live video feed

LEFT TO RIGHT: AMARDEEP SINGH, ANKIT MEHTA, ASHISH BHAT, VIPUL JOSHI AND RAHUL SINGH

